Pride and Prejudice

A simplified retelling

Original story by Jane Austen

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. A new neighbour

Mrs Bennet had important news. A wealthy young man had rented Netherfield, the large house near their home. His name was Mr Bingley, and he was unmarried.

The Bennets had five daughters: Jane, Elizabeth, Mary, Kitty and Lydia. Their home, Longbourn, could not pass to any of the daughters. After Mr Bennet’s death, a male relative would inherit it. Mrs Bennet therefore worried about their future. Unfortunately, she often showed her worry by speaking too loudly about marriage and money.

“You must visit him,” she told her husband. “Think of the girls!”

Mr Bennet enjoyed teasing his wife, but he did make the visit. Soon the family met Bingley at a local dance. He was friendly and cheerful. He danced twice with Jane, the eldest daughter, who was gentle and beautiful.

Bingley’s friend, Mr Darcy, was even richer. At first, everyone wanted to know him. But he stood apart and seemed unwilling to talk. When Bingley suggested that he dance with Elizabeth, Darcy refused. Elizabeth overheard him say that she was not attractive enough to

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tempt him.

She told the story afterwards with a laugh. Yet she remembered the insult. Darcy seemed proud, and Elizabeth had little reason to think well of him.

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2. Jane at Netherfield

Bingley’s sisters invited Jane to visit Netherfield. Mrs Bennet sent her on horseback, hoping that the approaching rain would make her stay overnight. Jane became wet on the journey and caught a bad cold.

Elizabeth walked across muddy fields to see her. Bingley’s sisters thought her dirty shoes and long walk showed poor manners. Elizabeth cared much more about her sister’s health than their opinion.

Bingley was clearly worried about Jane. Elizabeth began to hope that their growing friendship would become something lasting.

Darcy, meanwhile, was beginning to notice Elizabeth differently. Her lively eyes and independent opinions interested him. She did not agree with him simply because he was wealthy. Their conversations sometimes felt like small arguments, but he found himself wanting more of them.

Elizabeth did not see this. She still believed that he disliked her. Miss Bingley, who wanted Darcy’s attention for herself, noticed his interest and was not pleased.

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When Jane recovered, the sisters returned home. Mrs Bennet was disappointed that they had not stayed longer. Elizabeth was relieved to leave the uncomfortable company behind.

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3. Two very different men

Mr Collins, the relative who would inherit Longbourn, came to visit. He was a clergyman with an important patron, Lady Catherine de Bourgh. He mentioned her name so often that Elizabeth could almost predict his next sentence.

Collins wanted to marry one of the Bennet daughters. He thought this would make up for inheriting their home. When he learned that Jane might soon receive another proposal, he turned his attention to Elizabeth.

Around this time, a group of soldiers arrived in the nearby town. One officer, Mr Wickham, was charming and easy to talk to. Elizabeth liked him immediately.

Wickham told her that Darcy’s father had intended to help him become a clergyman. According to Wickham, Darcy had unfairly denied him that future after his father’s death.

The story fitted Elizabeth’s opinion of Darcy perfectly. She believed it without asking for other evidence. Wickham seemed open and pleasant; Darcy seemed cold and proud. To Elizabeth, the answer appeared obvious.

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At another dance, however, Wickham was absent. Elizabeth danced with Darcy instead. Their conversation was tense. Each believed the other was being unfair, and neither understood how little they really knew.

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4. A proposal and a surprise

Collins proposed to Elizabeth. He explained the advantages of the marriage as though he were listing the contents of a cupboard. He even mentioned Lady Catherine’s advice that he should marry.

Elizabeth refused politely. Collins assumed she was only pretending to refuse, as he believed young women sometimes did. She had to make her answer very clear.

Mrs Bennet was furious. Marriage to Collins would keep their home in the family. Mr Bennet, however, supported Elizabeth’s decision. He knew she could not respect or love this man.

A few days later, Elizabeth learned something unexpected. Her friend Charlotte Lucas had accepted Collins’s proposal.

Charlotte was older than Elizabeth and had little money. She did not expect a great romance. She wanted a secure home and believed she could manage life with Collins.

Elizabeth struggled to understand. She would rather

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remain unmarried than accept such a husband. But Charlotte had made her own choice in difficult circumstances.

Meanwhile, Bingley suddenly left Netherfield for London. His sisters suggested that he would not return soon. Jane tried to hide her disappointment. Elizabeth suspected that his friends had helped to separate him from her sister.

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5. A visit to Kent

Charlotte married Collins and invited Elizabeth to visit their home in Kent. Elizabeth discovered that Charlotte had arranged her rooms and daily activities carefully. This allowed her to enjoy quiet hours without her husband’s constant company.

Nearby stood Rosings, the grand home of Lady Catherine. She invited them to dinner and asked Elizabeth many personal questions. She gave advice on education, music and family matters, whether anyone wanted it or not.

Elizabeth answered with confidence. Lady Catherine was not used to a young woman who could disagree without becoming frightened.

Darcy arrived to visit his aunt, accompanied by his cousin Colonel Fitzwilliam. Elizabeth liked the colonel’s friendly manner. Darcy often visited the Collins home too, though he sometimes said very little.

During a conversation, Colonel Fitzwilliam mentioned that Darcy had recently saved a friend from an unsuitable marriage. He did not name the people

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involved. Elizabeth nevertheless realised that he probably meant Bingley and Jane.

She was deeply upset. Her sister had suffered quietly, and now Elizabeth believed she knew who was responsible.

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6. Darcy speaks

Darcy found Elizabeth alone and unexpectedly told her that he loved her. He asked her to marry him.

But his proposal also explained how hard he had tried to resist loving her because of her family and social position. He seemed to expect her to be grateful despite these objections.

Elizabeth refused. She told him that he had insulted her even while asking for her hand. She accused him of separating Jane and Bingley and of treating Wickham cruelly.

Darcy was shocked. He had expected difficulties from his own feelings, not such a complete refusal from her.

Elizabeth also said that his manner had never made her wish to marry him. This hurt him more than she understood at the time.

They parted angrily. Elizabeth felt certain that she had spoken honestly. Yet Darcy’s love was a surprise, and the conversation had left her shaken.

The next morning, he gave her a letter. He did not ask

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her to change her answer. He wanted to explain the two matters she had raised.

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7. The letter

Darcy admitted that he had helped persuade Bingley to leave Jane. He had believed that Jane did not return Bingley’s feelings. Her quiet manner had hidden them. He also admitted that he had kept Jane’s later visit to London from his friend.

He explained his concerns about the Bennet family’s public behaviour. Elizabeth disliked reading this, but she could not deny that some of it was true.

Then came Wickham’s story, and it was very different from the one Elizabeth knew. Darcy’s father had wanted to help Wickham. Later, Wickham had chosen money instead of entering the Church. He spent the money and then asked for the position he had already given up.

More seriously, he had tried to run away with Darcy’s young sister, Georgiana, hoping to gain her fortune. Darcy had discovered the plan in time. Georgiana had been only fifteen.

Elizabeth read the letter repeatedly. She remembered details that she had ignored because Wickham was charming. She also remembered how quickly she had

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accepted a story that supported her dislike of Darcy.

Her confidence began to fall apart. Darcy had been proud, but she had been prejudiced. She had trusted her first impression far too much.

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8. A warning at home

Back at Longbourn, Elizabeth told Jane most of what she had learned. She did not share Georgiana’s private story widely. They discussed whether to expose Wickham’s behaviour, but decided against making it public. Elizabeth believed he would soon leave the area with his regiment.

Lydia, the youngest Bennet sister, was invited to Brighton with the wife of an officer. She was excited about the soldiers, parties and freedom she expected there.

Elizabeth asked her father not to let Lydia go. Lydia was careless, easily excited and eager for attention. Elizabeth feared that she would embarrass herself and the family.

Mr Bennet treated the danger lightly. He thought Lydia would be troublesome at home if he refused. He allowed her to leave.

Elizabeth could not make him change his mind. She had begun to understand that laughing at foolish behaviour was not always enough. Sometimes a parent needed to

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prevent it.

That summer, she joined her aunt and uncle, Mr and Mrs Gardiner, on a journey. They were sensible, kind people whose company she enjoyed. Their travels took them near Darcy’s estate, Pemberley.

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9. Pemberley

Elizabeth agreed to visit Pemberley after hearing that Darcy was away. She did not want an awkward meeting. The estate’s beauty impressed her, but the housekeeper’s words impressed her more.

The housekeeper described Darcy as a generous employer and a good brother. This was not the man Elizabeth had imagined after the first dance.

Then Darcy returned unexpectedly.

Elizabeth was embarrassed, but he greeted her kindly. He treated the Gardiners with genuine respect. This mattered to her. He knew that her uncle worked in trade, yet he made no sign of looking down on him.

Darcy asked whether Elizabeth would meet Georgiana. His sister was shy, not proud, and Elizabeth liked her. Bingley was also there and asked warmly about Jane.

Elizabeth began to see Darcy through new eyes. He had listened to her criticism. His behaviour was more considerate, and he seemed sincerely pleased to know her relatives.

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She could not yet name her feelings with certainty. But her old dislike had disappeared. In its place were respect, gratitude and a growing wish to understand him better.

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10. Lydia disappears

Letters from Jane brought terrible news. Lydia had left Brighton with Wickham. At first, everyone hoped they had gone to Scotland to marry. Soon it became clear that there was no reliable sign of a wedding.

In their society, this could damage Lydia’s future and her sisters’ chances of marriage. More importantly, Lydia was young and with a man whom Elizabeth now knew she could not trust.

Darcy arrived while Elizabeth was distressed. She told him what had happened. He was serious and concerned, but soon left. Elizabeth feared that this family disaster had ended any possibility of a future with him.

She returned home immediately with the Gardiners. Mr Bennet had gone to London to search for Lydia. Mr Gardiner joined the search and later continued it when Mr Bennet returned.

Elizabeth blamed herself for remaining silent about Wickham. Her father also recognised that he should have taken her warning seriously.

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At last, Mr Gardiner wrote that Lydia and Wickham had been found. Wickham had agreed to marry her, and arrangements had been made. The family assumed that their uncle had paid a very large amount to achieve this.

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11. The hidden help

Lydia came home after the wedding, cheerful and full of stories. She did not understand the worry she had caused. During one conversation, she accidentally mentioned that Darcy had attended the wedding.

Elizabeth was astonished. She wrote to her aunt, who explained the truth.

Darcy had found Wickham and Lydia. He had paid Wickham’s debts, arranged money for the marriage and helped secure his future in the army. He had asked Mr Gardiner to keep his involvement private.

Darcy felt responsible because he had not made Wickham’s character known earlier. But Mrs Gardiner also believed that his love for Elizabeth had influenced his decision.

Elizabeth was moved. He had helped the very family whose behaviour had troubled him. He had dealt with Wickham despite their painful history. And he had done it without asking Elizabeth for thanks.

She now saw more than a proud man with good

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manners. She saw someone capable of difficult, practical kindness. Her gratitude was mixed with something warmer, though she did not know whether she would have another chance to tell him.

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12. Bingley returns

Bingley returned to Netherfield with Darcy. When they visited Longbourn, Mrs Bennet welcomed Bingley warmly and treated Darcy with much less interest. Elizabeth felt uncomfortable, knowing what Darcy had done in secret.

Bingley’s feelings for Jane had not changed. This time, Darcy did not stand between them. He had told Bingley that he had been wrong about Jane and had admitted hiding her visit to London.

Jane and Bingley soon became engaged. Jane was happy in her quiet way. She did not want to think badly of anyone, and her long disappointment finally ended.

Elizabeth was delighted for her sister. Her own future, however, remained uncertain. Darcy was polite, but they had few opportunities to speak privately.

She wondered whether he still loved her. He might believe that her refusal had been final. She knew she had changed, but he could not simply read her thoughts.

Honesty had brought them conflict before. Now she would need honesty again, this time without the anger

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and certainty that had once made her words so easy.

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13. Lady Catherine’s demand

Lady Catherine arrived at Longbourn without warning. She had heard a rumour that Elizabeth might marry Darcy and wanted to stop it.

She claimed that Darcy should marry her own daughter. She spoke of family, wealth and social rank as though these things settled the matter. Elizabeth, she said, did not belong in his world.

Elizabeth refused to accept this judgement. She did not claim to be engaged to Darcy, because she was not. But she would not promise never to accept him.

Lady Catherine became angrier. Elizabeth remained firm. Her future was not something another person could command.

The visit had an unexpected result. Lady Catherine reported the conversation to Darcy, hoping to turn him against Elizabeth. Instead, her report gave him hope. Elizabeth had refused to rule out marrying him. Perhaps her feelings were no longer the same.

Lady Catherine’s attempt to separate them had created

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an opening for them to understand one another at last.

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14. An honest conversation

When Elizabeth and Darcy finally walked together, she thanked him for helping Lydia. He was surprised that she knew. He said he had wanted to protect her from pain.

Then he told her that his feelings had not changed. If hers were still the same, he would not trouble her again.

This time, Elizabeth could answer differently. She explained that her feelings had changed a great deal. They spoke openly about the proposal, the letter and the mistakes each had made.

Darcy admitted that he had once expected others to accept his importance. Elizabeth’s refusal had shown him how selfish his behaviour could appear. Elizabeth admitted how badly she had judged him and Wickham.

Neither had become perfect. But each had learned to listen, question an easy judgement and respect the other more deeply.

Jane could hardly believe the news at first. Mr Bennet also worried that Elizabeth might marry someone she could not truly like. When she explained her love and

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Darcy’s character, he gave his consent.

Mrs Bennet’s opinion of Darcy changed immediately. His wealth now seemed much more important to her than his quiet manner.

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15. A different beginning

Jane married Bingley, and Elizabeth married Darcy. Their future was happier because it rested on better understanding, not on an impressive first appearance.

Elizabeth stayed close to the Gardiners, whose kindness had helped bring her and Darcy together. Georgiana welcomed her new sister and gradually became more confident around her.

Lydia and Wickham continued to be careless with money. Marriage had not changed their characters. Other family members also continued to have faults. The ending did not make everyone wise.

Yet Elizabeth and Darcy had changed something important in themselves. He had learned that wealth did not excuse unkindness. She had learned that quick intelligence did not protect a person from being unfair.

Their story began with an insult and a confident judgement. It ended with two people willing to admit that they had been wrong.

Pride had made it difficult for Darcy to see others clearly.

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Prejudice had made it difficult for Elizabeth to change her mind. Love became possible when both were ready to look again.

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Words to keep

inherit — receive money or property after someone dies. The daughters could not inherit Longbourn.

estate — a large house and the land belonging to it. Darcy invited the Gardiners to visit his estate.

proposal — a request to marry someone. Elizabeth refused Collins’s proposal.

patron — someone with money or influence who supports another person. Lady Catherine was Collins’s patron.

prejudice — an unfair judgement formed before knowing enough. Elizabeth’s prejudice made Wickham’s story easy to believe.

reputation — what other people generally think about someone. Wickham’s friendly manner protected his reputation for a time.

generous — willing to give time, help or money. The housekeeper described Darcy as a generous man.

consent — permission or agreement. Mr Bennet gave his consent after hearing Elizabeth’s reasons.

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After reading

Elizabeth changes her mind after reading Darcy’s letter. Which parts of the story did she believe too quickly, and why?

Compare Darcy’s first proposal with his final conversation with Elizabeth. What has changed in how he speaks and listens?

Charlotte chooses security when she marries Collins. How do her circumstances differ from Elizabeth’s?

Think of one moment when a character’s actions tell you more than their words. Explain your choice using the story.

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